

THE PELHAM GROUP NW · FREE GUIDE

before you list —

The Pre-Sale Renovation Playbook

The updates that pay you back before you sell — and how to make them without spending a cent until closing.

SNOHOMISH COUNTY EDITION · 2026



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17 yrs · 176 homes · SRES

First, the truth nobody tells you about selling.

hi, I'm Kim —

For 17 years I've helped Snohomish County families sell homes, and here's what I've learned: the home that sells for the most isn't the nicest one on the block. It's the one that was *prepared*. A focused, affordable prep is the single biggest lever you have on your final number — bigger than your agent's commission, bigger than the season, often bigger than the list price itself.

This guide is the exact playbook I use with my own clients. Use it to spend smart, skip the money-pits, and walk into your sale knowing you left nothing on the table.

— Kim

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Buyers price four things. Spend there. Ignore the rest.

A buyer forms 80% of their opinion in the first eight minutes — and they form it in four places. Every dollar of prep should go to one of these. Money spent elsewhere rarely comes back.

1 • The kitchen

The single most-priced room. Clean lines, light counters, current hardware and paint move the number more than any other space.

2 • The primary bath

Buyers read “cared for” or “deferred” here instantly. Fresh grout, a new vanity, and bright lighting do the work.

3 • Light & space

Paint, decluttering, and lighting make rooms feel larger and newer. The cheapest dollars with the highest return, every time.

4 • The first impression

Curb, entry, and smell. If the outside and the doorway feel loved, buyers walk in already wanting to say yes.

if it doesn't serve one of these four — think twice before you spend.

Ranked by return in our market.

Rough ranges from recent Snohomish County prep work. Yours will vary — that's what the walkthrough is for.

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|---|---|----------------|
| 1 | Fresh interior paint
One warm, neutral color throughout. Nothing makes a home feel newer for less. | \$3–6k → ~2× |
| 2 | Deep clean, declutter & stage
Edit by a third, then stage the rooms buyers price. Photos and showings both win. | \$2–5k → ~3× |
| 3 | Lighting & hardware refresh
Modern fixtures, warm bulbs, updated knobs and pulls. Small spend, instant "current." | \$800–2k → ~3× |
| 4 | Kitchen refresh (not remodel)
Paint or reface cabinets, new hardware, updated counters if dated. Skip the gut. | \$4–9k → ~2× |
| 5 | Primary bath refresh
New vanity, faucet, mirror, light, and fresh grout. Reads brand-new for a modest spend. | \$2–5k → ~2× |
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|----------|---|-----------------------|
| 6 | Flooring that's tired
Refinish hardwood; replace worn carpet with a neutral. Buyers subtract more than it costs to fix. | \$3–8k → ~1.5× |
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| 7 | Curb appeal & front door
Trim, mulch, a painted door, clean exterior. The first photo and the first step inside. | \$1–3k → ~2.5× |
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| 8 | The pre-inspection fixes
Handle the obvious items now — they cost less to fix than to negotiate later. | varies → protects price |
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| 9 | A cohesive, current palette
Counters, fixtures, and paint that agree with each other. Cohesion reads as quality. | included above |
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the one rule

Update to feel *clean, light, and current* — never to someone else's taste. You're removing reasons to say no, not building your dream kitchen.

The money-pits.

These feel productive and almost never return what they cost at the closing table. Save the cash — or put it toward the nine that work.

× A full kitchen gut

A \$40k remodel rarely returns \$40k. A refresh captures most of the gain for a fraction of the cost.

× High-end appliances

Buyers don't pay a premium for pro ranges in a mid-market home. Clean and working beats luxury.

× Additions & sunrooms

Long timelines, permits, and you'll recoup pennies on the dollar. Not before a sale.

× Pools & hot tubs

As likely to deter a buyer as delight one. Never add one to sell.

× Bold, personal finishes

That statement tile you love narrows your buyer pool. Keep it neutral.

× Over-landscaping

Tidy and green sells. Elaborate gardens read as "maintenance" to a buyer.

when in doubt, ask me before you spend. that's what I'm here for.

Same house. A very different first impression.

A recent Snohomish County prep I managed start to finish — paint, new flooring, a refreshed fireplace, lighting, and full staging. Same room. Same square footage. A very different first impression.



● Prepped, staged & listed now

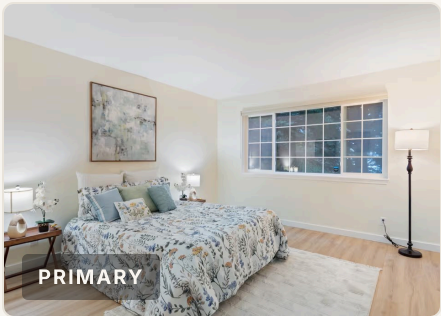
paint, floors, fireplace & stage

THE REST OF THE HOME, PREPPED & STAGED

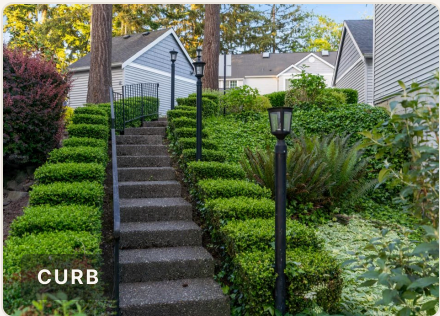
on the market now



KITCHEN



PRIMARY



CURB

\$0 upfront. I prep it. You pay at closing.

You don't need cash on hand or a contractor in your phone. For qualifying listings, I coordinate the whole prep and front the cost — it's simply repaid from your proceeds when the home sells.

1

We walk through together

I build your prioritized plan from the nine updates — only what will actually move your number. You approve every line.

2

I front the cost & manage the work

Vetted local trades I've trusted for years. I project-manage every step and stage it with my own hands.

3

You pay at closing

The investment comes out of your sale proceeds — after the prep has already done its job and lifted your price.

\$0

out of pocket

102.3%

avg sale-to-list

2

clients at a time

From walkthrough to live in three weeks.

WEEK ONE

Plan & order

We walk through, set the prioritized scope, and lock the budget. I order materials and schedule the trades the same week.

WEEK TWO

The work

Paint, repairs, lighting, and the kitchen and bath refreshes happen in sequence. I'm on-site managing every day.

WEEK THREE

Stage, shoot & launch

I stage the home, bring in the photographer, and we go live — with the home showing at its absolute best.

most homes I prep are on the market within 21 days.

Walk your own home like a buyer.

Print this page. Carry it room to room. Anything you check is a place to start.

ENTRY & CURB

- ☐ Front door painted & hardware shines
- ☐ Lawn trimmed, beds mulched, pots fresh
- ☐ Clean exterior, windows & gutters

KITCHEN

- ☐ Counters cleared to near-empty
- ☐ Cabinet fronts & hardware updated
- ☐ Caulk, grout & faucet look new

BATHROOMS

- ☐ Fresh grout & caulk lines
- ☐ New vanity, mirror & lighting
- ☐ Spotless glass & fixtures

LIVING & BEDROOMS

- ☐ Walls a warm neutral, no scuffs
- ☐ Declutter surfaces & closets by a third
- ☐ Warm bulbs, all fixtures matching

FLOORS & LIGHT

- ☐ Hardwood refinished / carpet fresh
- ☐ Windows washed, screens cleaned
- ☐ Every room bright at showing time

THE SENSES

- ☐ Neutral smell — no pet or smoke
- ☐ Deep clean top to bottom
- ☐ Minor repairs from your inspection list

your next chapter —

Let's find your number together.

I keep just two clients at a time, so every prep gets my full attention — and my own two hands. If this guide was useful, the walkthrough is free. Let's talk before you list.

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Brokered by Katrina Eileen Real Estate.
Home pictured is a current listing, shown to
illustrate prep — not a completed sale.
Figures illustrative; not a guarantee of
results.